

YOUR MONEY, THEIR CHOICES

A Data-Driven Investigation into Nigeria's ₦51.6 Trillion 2026 Federal Budget

- What does Nigeria's largest-ever budget tell us about government priorities?
- Where does debt end and investment begin?
- What does it mean for the market trader, the teacher, the patient, the farmer?

Produced by **Team Metro (Group 8)** Source: **Budget Office of the Federation** – 2026 Appropriation Bill & Details

1 THE BIG PICTURE

₦51,592,233,171,028. That is the number at the top of Nigeria's 2026 Federal Appropriation Bill – the largest budget in the country's history. Written in full: **Fifty-One Trillion, Five Hundred and Ninety-Two Billion Naira.**

This is money that, in theory, belongs to every Nigerian — collected through taxes, oil revenues, and borrowing — and distributed through 56 Federal Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs). To put it in context: it is roughly 4.7 times the entire economy of Cameroon. It is the single largest spending commitment any Nigerian government has ever made.

But before a single classroom is built, before a hospital receives supplies, before a kilometer of road is paved, one critical question must be asked: after all prior commitments are settled, how much of this record budget actually reaches the Nigerian people?

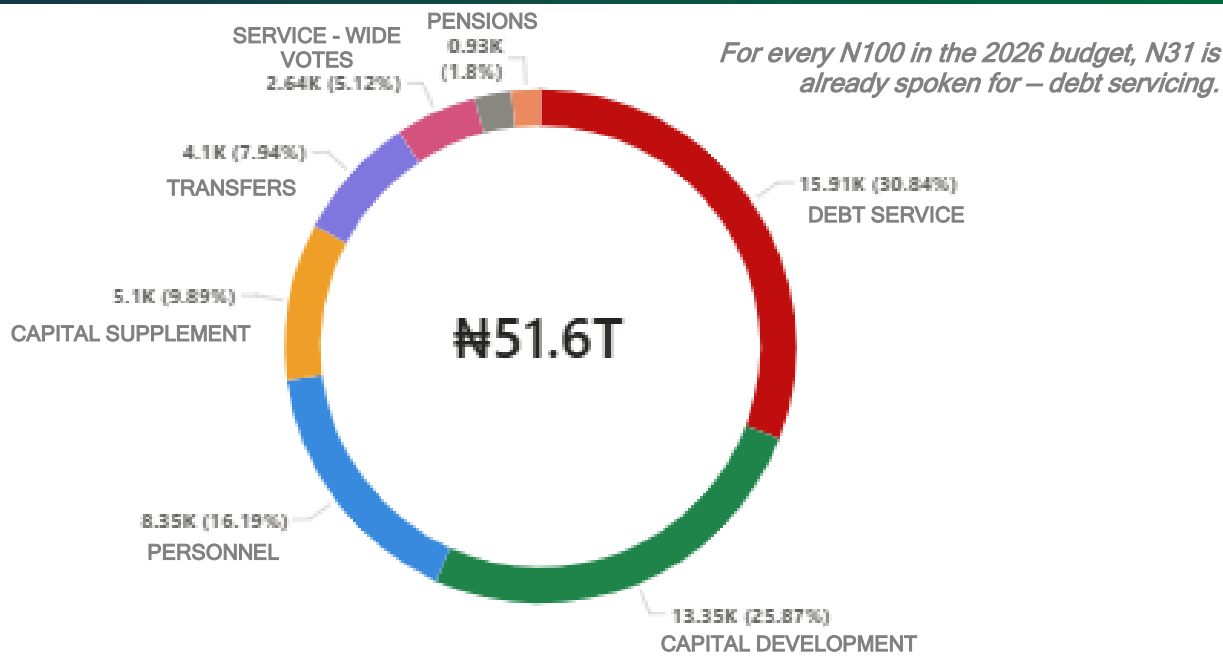
KEY FINDING: Nigeria's 2026 budget is its largest ever — but size alone does not determine impact. Where the money goes matters more than how much there is.

₦51.6T TOTAL BUDGET Largest in Nigerian history
₦15.9T DEBT SERVICE 30.8% of total budget
₦13.3T CAPITAL DEVELOPMENT 25.9% — money to build
56 TOTAL MDAS Ministries, Depts & Agencies

1.1 HOW THE BUDGET IS STRUCTURED

The ₦51.6 trillion budget is not one pot of money freely distributed. It flows through different fund categories, each with its own rules and purposes.

HOW NIGERIA’S ₦51.6T BUDGET IS DISTRIBUTED, WITH DEBT LEADING BEFORE SERVICE DELIVERY BEGINS.



Fund Category	Allocation (₦)	% of Total
Debt Services	₦15,909,361,631,657	30.8%
Capital Development Fund (Main)	₦13,345,673,201,839	25.9%
Personnel Costs (Main Envelope)	₦8,354,176,058,492	16.2%
CRF - Capital Supplementation	₦5,102,872,076,986	9.9%
Statutory Transfers	₦4,097,381,103,856	7.9%
CRF - Service-Wide Votes	₦2,641,587,108,707	5.1%
Overhead Costs	₦1,214,122,707,677	2.4%
Pensions & Gratuities	₦927,059,281,814	1.8%
TOTAL	₦51,592,233,171,028	100.0%

Table 1 — Budget breakdown by fund category

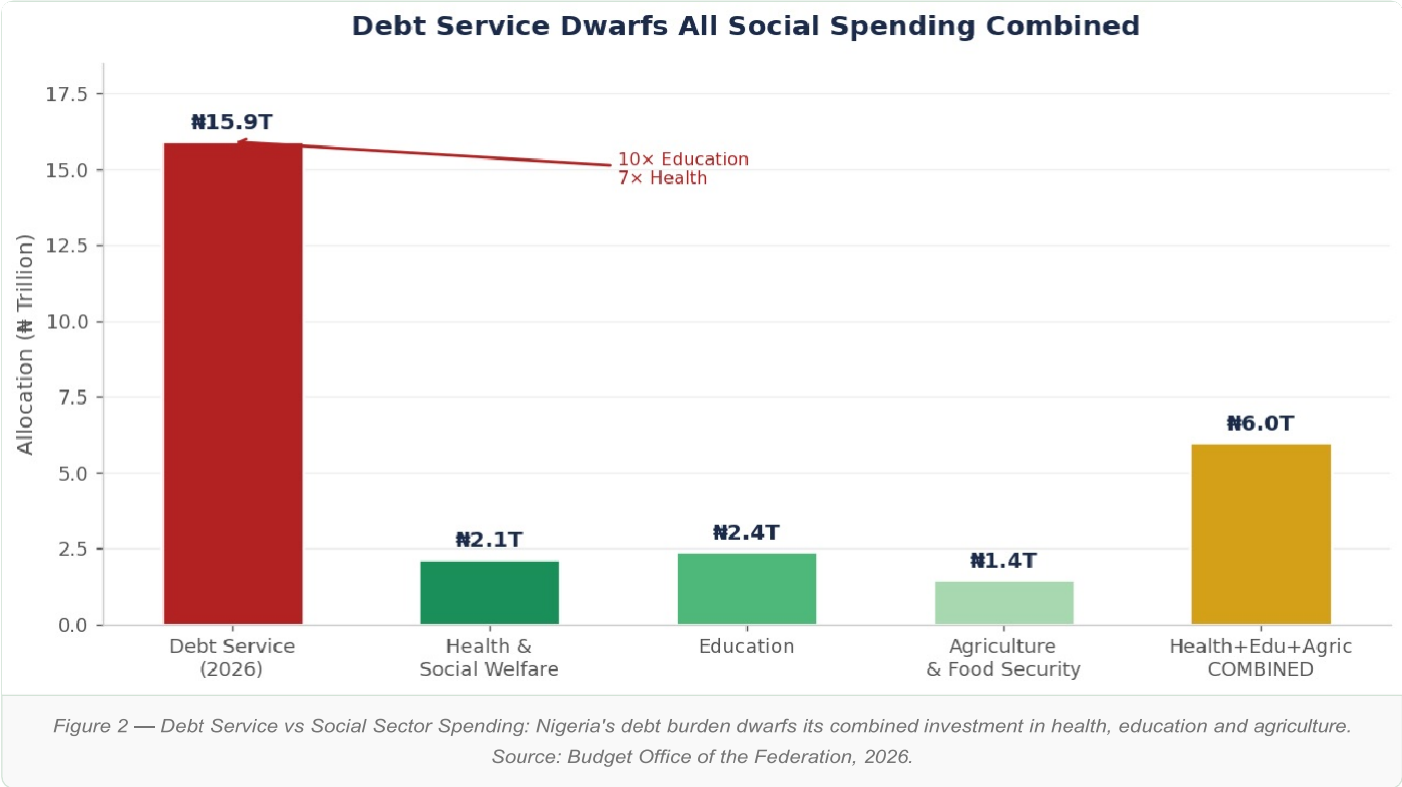
2 THE DEBT TRAP — 31 KOBO OF EVERY NAIRA

Here is the most important number in the 2026 budget that no government official will put on a billboard:

₦15,909,361,631,657 — nearly one-third of the entire budget — goes directly to servicing Nigeria's debts. Not building roads. Not hiring doctors. Not paying teachers. Just repaying creditors.

For every ₦100 the Federal Government plans to spend in 2026, roughly ₦31 goes straight to debt service before a single government service is delivered. This is money that leaves Nigeria's economy in the form of interest and principal repayments to domestic and foreign lenders.

To put this in human terms: Nigeria allocates ₦2.15 trillion to health for 220 million people. It allocates ₦2.4 trillion to education. But it allocates ₦15.9 trillion — more than health and education combined, multiplied by three — to debt repayment alone.



Comparison	Amount (₦)
Debt Service (2026)	₦15,909,361,631,657
Health + Education + Agriculture COMBINED	₦5,996,100,791,568
Debt Service is larger by	₦9,913,260,840,089
New borrowing planned (Financing Items)	₦25,273,311,905,209

Table 2 — Debt service compared to social sector spending

2.1 THE BORROWING CYCLE

What makes this particularly alarming is the financing side of the budget. Nigeria's own revenue — from oil, taxes, and government enterprises — amounts to ₦33.2 trillion. Total planned expenditure is ₦58.5 trillion. The gap: **₦25.3 trillion**, which the government plans to fill almost entirely through new borrowing.

In other words: Nigeria is borrowing ₦25.3 trillion in 2026 partly to pay off ₦15.9 trillion in debts from previous borrowing. The cycle is self-reinforcing. Each year's borrowing becomes the next year's debt service problem, crowding out more and more of the budget that should be reaching ordinary Nigerians.

Budget Flow: Debt, Spending, and Structure

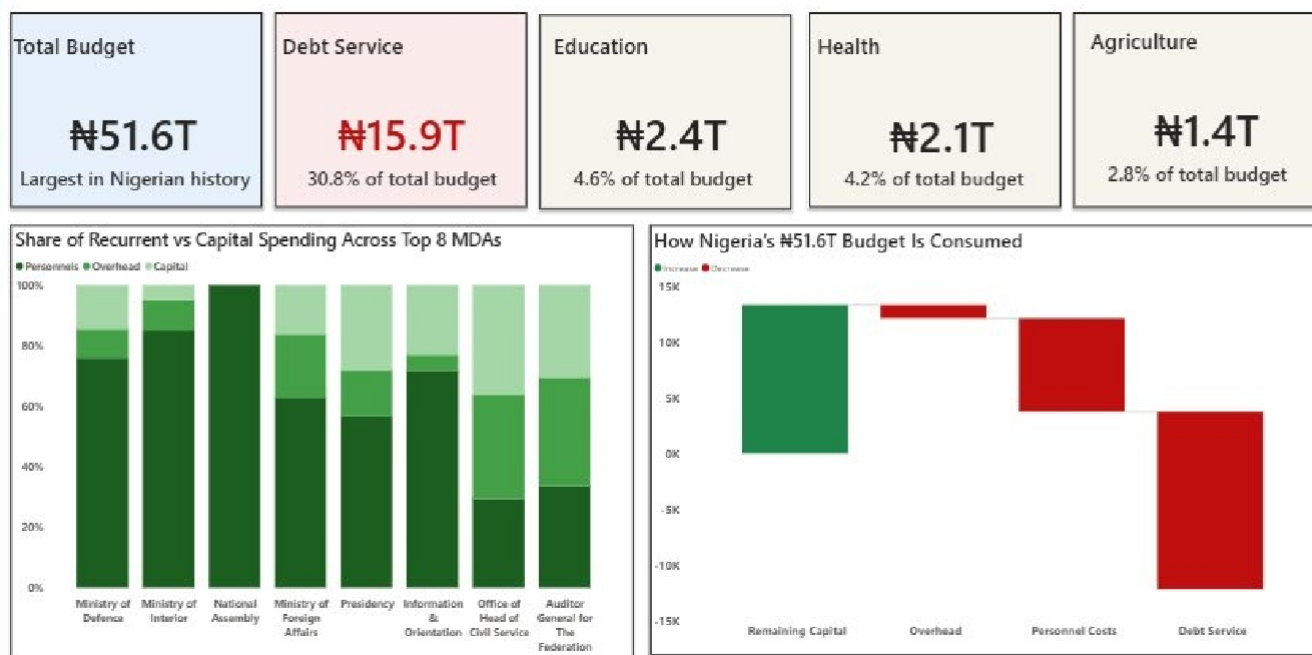


Figure 3 — Budget Flow: Debt, Spending, and Structure. Recurrent vs capital spending across top MDAs, and how Nigeria's ₦51.6T budget is consumed. Source: Budget Office of the Federation, 2026.

3 THE PEOPLE'S SHARE — HEALTH, EDUCATION & THE BROKEN PROMISES

In 2001, African heads of state — including Nigeria's — signed the Abuja Declaration, committing to allocate at least **15% of national budgets** to healthcare. In 2026, Nigeria allocates **4.2%** of its total budget to health. Twenty-five years after making that promise, Nigeria is at less than a third of the target.

Education fares slightly better on paper — receiving **₦2.4 trillion (4.6%)** — but still falls far short of UNESCO's recommended 20% benchmark. With over 10 million out-of-school children and decades of underinvestment in university infrastructure, the gap between what is needed and what is budgeted is felt every school day.

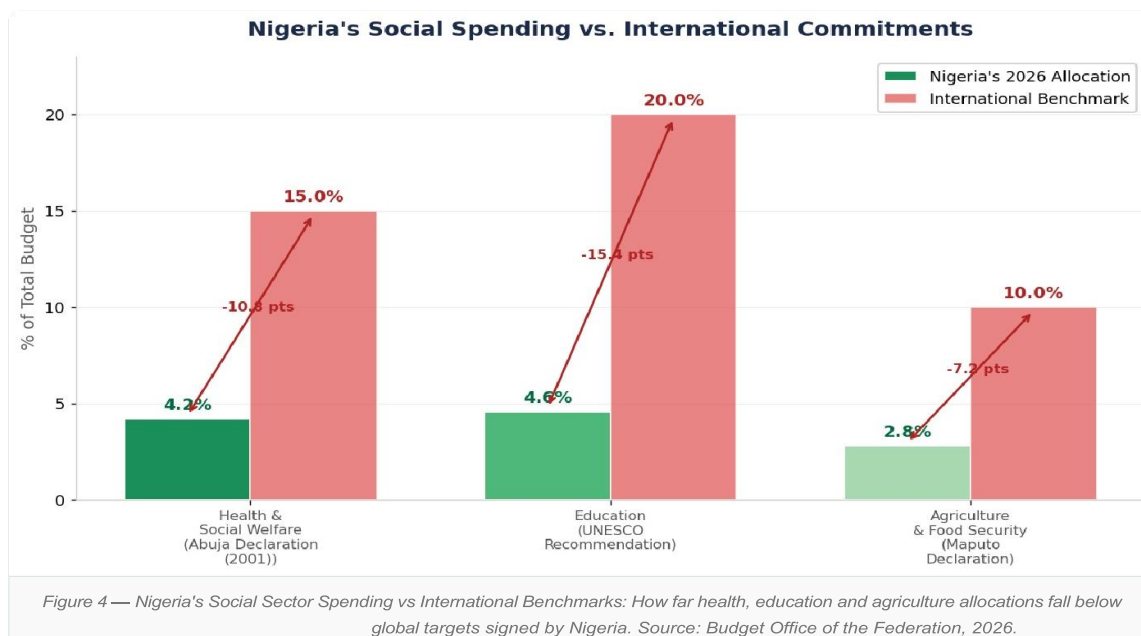


Figure 4 — Nigeria's Social Sector Spending vs International Benchmarks: How far health, education and agriculture allocations fall below global targets signed by Nigeria. Source: Budget Office of the Federation, 2026.

Sector	Allocation	% of Budget	Benchmark	Gap
Health & Social Welfare	₦2,149.4B	4.2%	15% (Abuja Decl.)	– 10.8 pts
Education	₦2,398.8B	4.6%	20% (UNESCO)	– 15.4 pts
Agriculture & Food Security	₦1,448.0B	2.8%	10% (Maputo Decl.)	– 7.2 pts
Environment	₦164.1B	0.3%	—	—

Table 3 — Social spending vs. international benchmarks

3.1 WHAT THIS MEANS PER PERSON

Dividing these allocations across Nigeria's estimated population of 220 million people tells a sharper story:

Every Nigerian effectively contributes ₦72,315 to debt repayment this year — but receives only ₦9,770 worth of health services, ₦10,903 in education support, and just ₦6,581 in agricultural assistance.

Sector	Total Allocation	Per Nigerian Per Year
Health & Social Welfare	₦2,149,365,867,131	≈ ₦9,770
Education	₦2,398,761,320,016	≈ ₦10,903
Agriculture & Food Security	₦1,447,973,604,421	≈ ₦6,581
Debt Service (for comparison)	₦15,909,361,631,657	≈ ₦72,315

Table 4 — Per-capita budget allocation across key sectors (based on 220M population)

3.2 AGRICULTURE: AMBITIOUS ALLOCATION, EXECUTION RISK

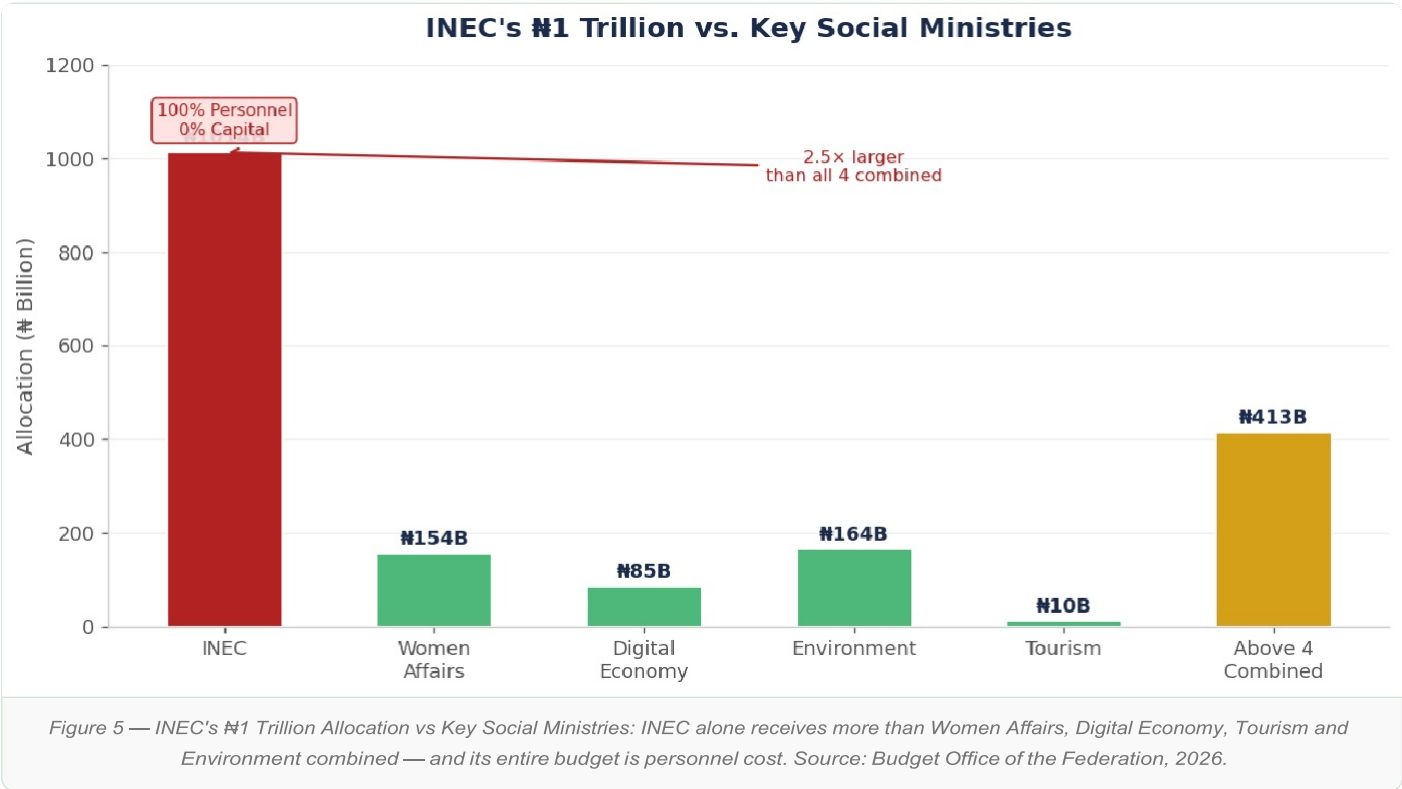
The Federal Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security receives ₦1.45 trillion — a significant allocation on paper. However, 89.8% of that (approximately ₦1.3 trillion) is tagged as capital spending, making it almost entirely dependent on project execution — historically Nigeria's weakest link. At a time when food prices are crushing market traders and households across the country, the question is not just how much was allocated, but whether it will actually be spent.

Only ₦136 billion — 9.4% of agriculture's allocation — is personnel cost, raising questions about whether there is sufficient human capacity on the ground to execute these projects. Budgets that exist only on paper feed no one.

One number in this budget stands out as politically striking and deserving of public scrutiny:

₦1,013,778,401,602 — over one trillion naira — allocated to the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC). Every single naira is classified as personnel cost. Zero capital. Zero overhead.

This is an extraordinary departure from normal budgeting. What personnel cost runs to ₦1 trillion for an electoral body in a non-election year? The 2027 general elections are eighteen months away, and this allocation — larger than the budgets of Women Affairs, Digital Economy, Tourism, and the Environment combined — raises a question every Nigerian voter deserves answered.



Ministry / Agency	Total Allocation	Personnel	Capital
INEC	₦1,013,778,401,602	100%	0%
Women Affairs	₦154,315,760,358	—	—
Communications & Digital Economy	₦84,560,242,389	—	—
Tourism	₦10,417,248,347	—	—
Environment	₦164,144,903,258	—	—

Table 5 — INEC's allocation compared to key social ministries

BUILD SOMETHING OR PAY SOMEONE? — THE CAPITAL VS PERSONNEL DIVIDE

A budget is a statement of intent. But intent can be measured two ways: by how much a government plans to **invest** (capital expenditure — roads, hospitals, equipment, infrastructure) and how much it plans to **consume** (recurrent expenditure — salaries, allowances, running costs). The balance between the two tells us whether a government is building a country or simply maintaining a bureaucracy.

Ministry	Personnel (₦B)	Capital (₦B)	Capital Ratio
Ministry of Works	₦12.9B	₦3,437.0B	98.5%
Ministry of Power	₦6.2B	₦1,096.7B	99.1%
Ministry of Agriculture	₦136.3B	₦1,300.5B	89.8%
Ministry of Health	₦1,170.5B	₦924.2B	43.0%
Ministry of Education	₦1,679.4B	₦591.6B	24.6%
Ministry of Defense	₦2,392.9B	₦464.5B	14.7%
Ministry of Niger Delta	₦1,326.9B	₦17.4B	1.3%
INEC	₦1,013.8B	₦0.0B	0.0%

Table 6 — Capital vs Personnel ratio across key ministries

5.1 THE NIGER DELTA PARADOX

The Federal Ministry of Niger Delta presents one of the most troubling stories in the entire budget. The region that produces Nigeria's oil wealth — the source of the revenue that funds this entire budget — receives a ministry allocation that is, in effect, almost entirely a salary bill. **₦1.33 trillion in personnel costs versus just ₦17.4 billion in capital. A capital ratio of 1.3%.**

The people of the Niger Delta live with polluted rivers, gas flaring, and damaged farmlands caused by the extraction of the oil that finances this budget. In return, their dedicated ministry allocates less than 2% of its funds to actually building anything in their communities. This is a number that deserves a national conversation.

THE UNFINISHED BUSINESS — ONGOING VS NEW PROJECTS

Perhaps the most revealing analysis in this entire report comes not from the summary budget numbers, but from examining what the 2026 budget actually plans to build — and crucially, **how much of that plan is old, unfinished work versus genuinely new investment.**

An analysis of all 23,617 capital projects listed in the 2026 Appropriation Bill Details reveals a striking and sobering picture:

Of 23,617 capital projects in the 2026 budget: 23,067 are ONGOING (97.7%) | Only 357 are NEW (1.5%) | ₦16.47 trillion is going to ongoing projects vs ₦3.27 trillion to new ones

This means that out of every 100 projects in Nigeria's 2026 capital budget, **fewer than 2 are genuinely new.** The rest are carry-overs from previous budgets — projects that have been funded year after year but remain incomplete. This is not a sign of a government launching new investments. It is a sign of a government struggling to finish what it already started.

₦27.3T

TOTAL PROJECT ALLOCATION

23K

TOTAL PROJECTS

98.5%

ONGOING PROJECTS

Carry-overs from previous years

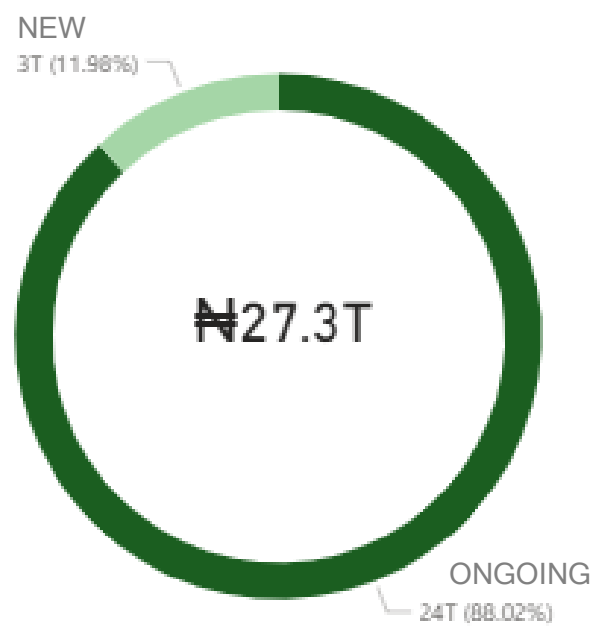


Figure 6 — Ongoing vs New Capital Projects: The donut chart illustrates the overwhelming dominance of carry-over (ongoing) projects at 88% by value. Source: Budget Office of the Federation, 2026.

Project Status	Number	% of Total	Total Amount
ONGOING	23,067	97.7%	₦16,471,969,282,736
NEW	357	1.5%	₦3,273,068,153,880
Other / Unclassified	193	0.8%	Negligible
TOTAL	23,617	100%	≈ ₦19.7 trillion

Table 7 — Ongoing vs new projects across the 2026 capital budget

6.1 TOP 10 MINISTRIES BY ONGOING PROJECTS

The following agencies carry the heaviest backlog of unfinished work — projects funded in previous budgets that remain incomplete and are being re-funded in 2026:

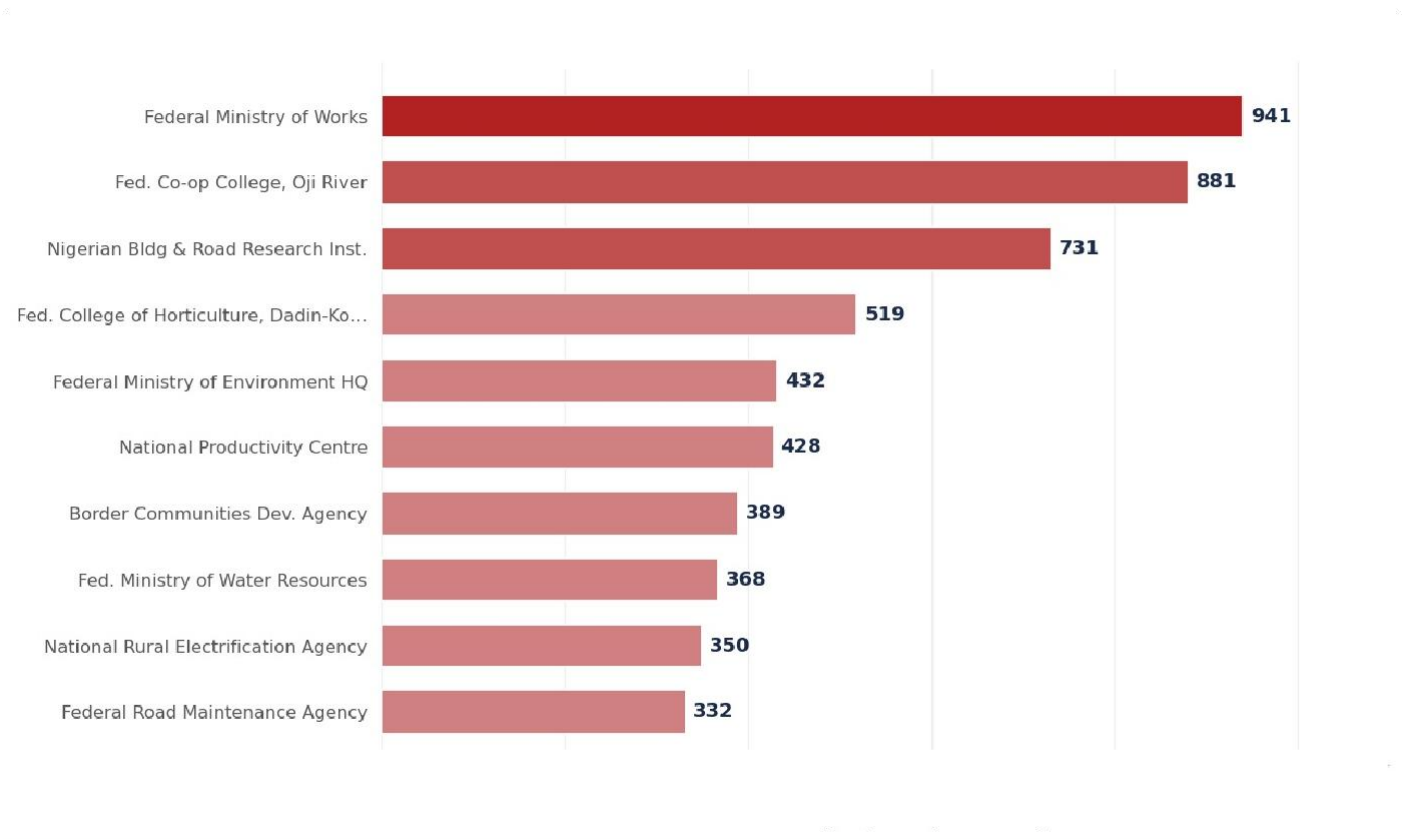


Figure 7 — Top 10 Agencies by Backlog of Unfinished Projects: The Federal Ministry of Works leads with 941 ongoing carry-over projects. Source: Budget Office of the Federation, 2026.

Rank	Ministry / Agency	Ongoing Projects
1	Federal Ministry of Works	941
2	Federal Co-operative College, Oji River	881
3	Nigerian Building & Road Research Institute, Lagos	731
4	Federal College of Horticulture, Dadin-Kowa	519
5	Federal Ministry of Environment HQ	432
6	National Productivity Centre	428
7	Border Communities Development Agency	389
8	Federal Ministry of Water Resources & Sanitation	368
9	National Rural Electrification Agency	350
10	Federal Road Maintenance Agency	332

Table 8 — Top 10 agencies by number of ongoing (carry-over) projects

6.2 TOP 10 MINISTRIES BY NEW PROJECTS

In contrast, these are the agencies launching genuinely new work in 2026 — the areas where the government is making fresh commitments:

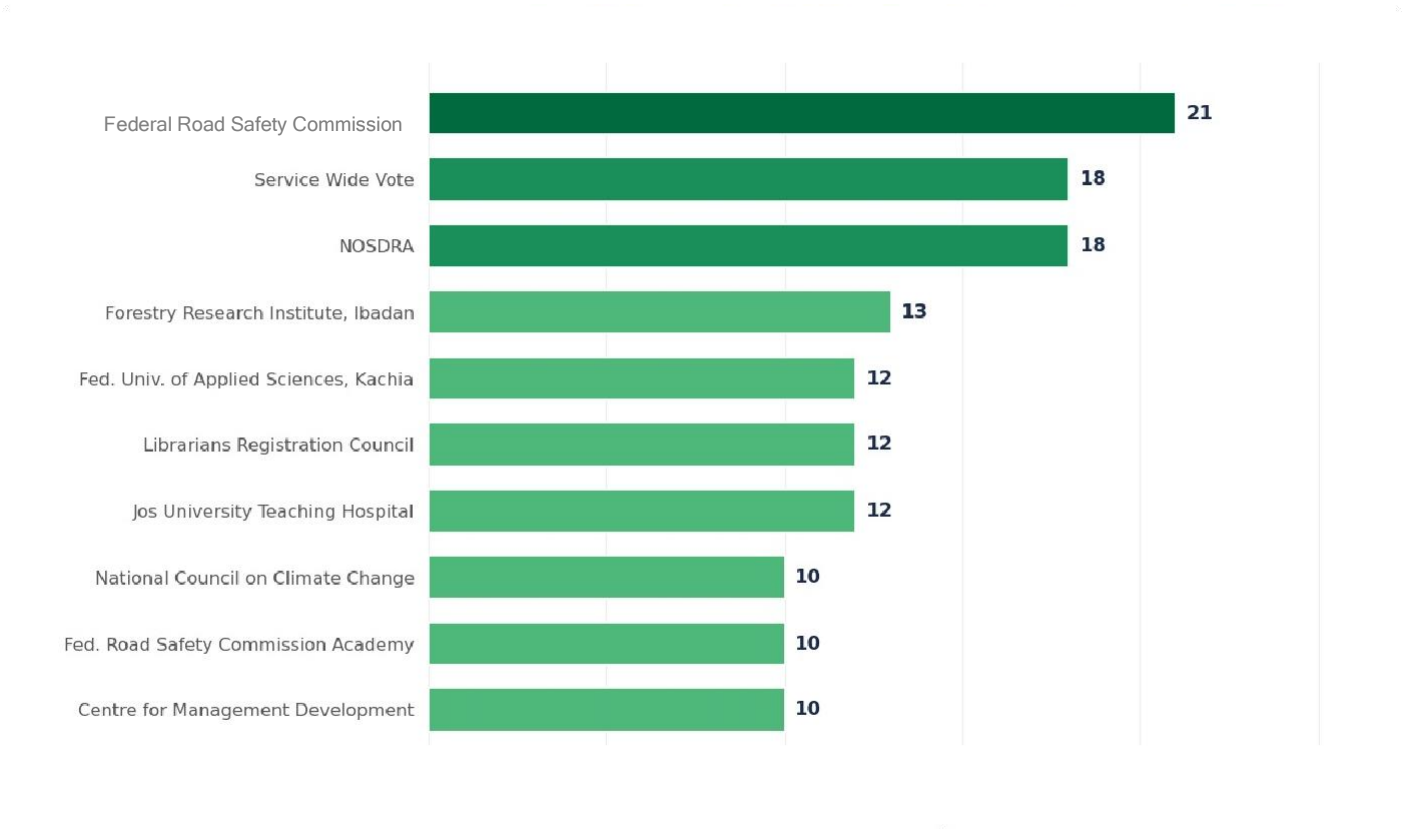


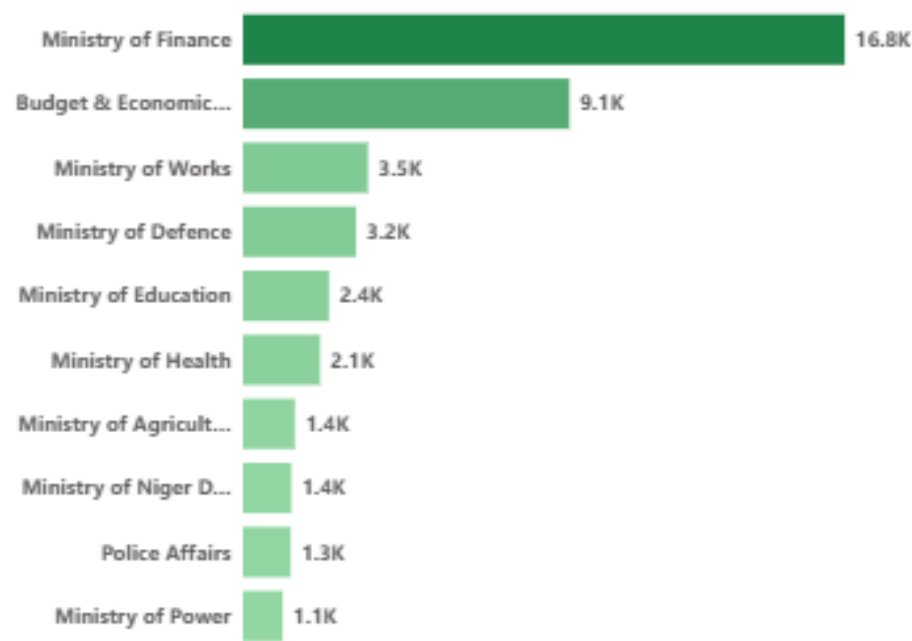
Figure 8 — Top 10 Agencies Executing New Contracts in 2026. Note the relatively small numbers — only 21 at most — underscoring how few truly new projects the 2026 budget contains. Source: Budget Office of the Federation, 2026.

Rank	Ministry / Agency	New Projects
1	Fed. Road Safety Commission Inspectorate Training School	21
2	Service Wide Vote	18
3	NOSDRA	18
4	Forestry Research Institute, Ibadan	13
5	Federal University of Applied Sciences, Kachia	12
6	Librarians Registration Council of Nigeria	12
7	Jos University Teaching Hospital	12
8	National Council on Climate Change	10
9	Federal Road Safety Commission Academy	10
10	Centre for Management Development	10

Table 9 — Top 10 agencies by number of new projects in 2026

Every budget creates winners and losers. Below is the complete ranking of Nigeria's top 10 MDAs by total allocation — stripped of technical language and presented in plain numbers. Note that the Federal Ministry of Finance's ₦16.78 trillion allocation is almost entirely composed of the ₦15.9 trillion debt service passing through it to creditors.

Top 10 Ministries by Budget Allocation



#	Ministry / Agency	Total Allocation	% of Budget
1	Federal Ministry of Finance*	₦16,781.3B	32.5%
2	Fed. Min. of Budget & Economic Planning	₦9,103.0B	17.6%
3	Federal Ministry of Works	₦3,485.7B	6.8%
4	Ministry of Defense	₦3,154.4B	6.1%
5	Federal Ministry of Education	₦2,398.8B	4.6%
6	Federal Ministry of Health & Social Welfare	₦2,149.4B	4.2%
7	Federal Ministry of Agriculture & Food Security	₦1,448.0B	2.8%
8	Federal Ministry of Niger Delta	₦1,350.9B	2.6%
9	Federal Ministry of Police Affairs	₦1,330.4B	2.6%
10	Federal Ministry of Power	₦1,107.1B	2.1%

Table 10 — Top 10 MDAs by total budget allocation (2026). *Finance Ministry's allocation is largely a pass-through for debt service payments to creditors.

✓ CONCLUSION: WHAT THIS BUDGET SAYS ABOUT NIGERIA IN 2026

Nigeria's 2026 budget is, in many ways, a story of inherited constraints and deferred choices. The debt burden is real, significant, and largely pre-determined by decisions made in previous administrations. The government did not freely choose to spend ₦15.9 trillion on debt service — it is simply the accumulated cost of years of borrowing.

But the choices that are made within the remaining budget reveal clear priorities: elections and security rank above health and education; personnel costs crowd out capital investment in several key agencies; and critical social investments in health, education, and agriculture remain well below globally recommended benchmarks.

Most significantly, an analysis of 23,617 capital projects shows that 97.7% of them are ongoing — carry-overs from previous years that remain unfinished. Nigeria is not launching a new era of investment in 2026. It is, largely, trying to complete the investments it already promised in 2024 and 2025.

"A budget is not just numbers — it is a moral document. It tells you what a government values, what it fears, and who it serves."

1 THE DEBT PROBLEM IS STRUCTURAL

Nigeria cannot build its way out of underdevelopment if 31 kobo of every budget naira goes to creditors before a single service is delivered. Debt restructuring and domestic revenue mobilization must be national priorities — not just talking points.

2 97.7% OF CAPITAL PROJECTS ARE UNFINISHED BUSINESS

Before celebrating new budget announcements, Nigerians should ask: will this actually be completed? The evidence from 23,067 ongoing projects suggests that Nigeria's budget execution capacity is the critical gap between promise and delivery.

3 HEALTH AND EDUCATION ARE CHRONICALLY UNDERFUNDED

At 4.2% and 4.6% respectively, Nigeria's health and education allocations are not just below international benchmarks — they are below what the country's own crisis demands. Every year this continues is a year of lost human capital that cannot be recovered.

NOTE ON THE ₦68 TRILLION APPROVED BUDGET: Team Metro is aware that the National Assembly approved a revised 2026 Federal Budget of approximately ₦68 trillion — higher than the ₦51.6 trillion figure analyzed in this report. However, as of publication, only the Executive's Appropriation Bill was publicly available on the Budget Office of the Federation website (budgetoffice.gov.ng). All analysis is therefore based on the officially published Executive proposal. When the approved version becomes publicly available, a revised analysis may produce different figures.

DATA NOTE: This report was produced using data sourced directly from the 2026 Federal Government of Nigeria Appropriation Bill and Appropriation Bill Details, published by the Budget Office of the Federation (budgetoffice.gov.ng). All 23,617 capital projects were individually verified. All figures have been independently confirmed against the official Executive proposal total of ₦51,592,233,171,028. No figures have been estimated or interpolated.